

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 1 (Verses 1-10)

The Samkhya Karika by Ishvarakrishna is the foundational text of the Samkhya school of classical Indian philosophy. This document compiles a highly detailed word-by-word breakdown of the first ten verses, exploring the core principles of Purusha, Prakriti, the nature of suffering, and the means of valid knowledge.

Verse 1: The Purpose of Inquiry (Suffering)

Sanskrit Text

duḥkha-traya-abhighātāt jijñāsā tad-apaghātake hetau |
drṣṭe sā apārthā cen na ekānta-atyantato abhāvāt ||

English Translation

Because of the torment of the threefold suffering, there arises a desire to know the means to destroy it. If it is said that this inquiry is useless because visible (worldly) means exist, we say no, because those worldly means are neither absolute nor permanent.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
duḥkha	suffering / pain
traya	threefold
abhighātāt	from the strike / impact / torment
jijñāsā	desire to know / inquiry
tad	that (referring to suffering)
apaghātake	in the destroyer / removal
hetau	for the cause / means
drṣṭe	in the seen / worldly (remedies)
sā	that (inquiry)
apārthā	useless / without purpose
cen	if
na	not so
ekānta	absolute (certainty of cure)
atyantato	permanent (non-return of pain)
abhāvāt	because of the absence / non-existence

Verse 2: The Insufficiency of Scriptural Means

Sanskrit Text

dr̥ṣṭavad ānuśravikaḥ sa hy aviśuddhikṣayaātīśayayuktaḥ |
tadviparītaḥ śreyān vyaktāvyaktajñavijñānāt ||

English Translation

The revealed (scriptural) means are like the visible ones; they are linked to impurity, decay, and excess. A superior method, different from both, is the discriminative knowledge of the Manifest (Vyakta), the Unmanifest (Avyakta), and the Knower (Purusha).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dr̥ṣṭavad	like the seen (visible means)
ānuśravikaḥ	the revealed / scriptural (Vedic means)
saḥ	that
hi	indeed
aviśuddhi	impurity
kṣaya	decay / destruction
atiśaya	excess / inequality
yuktaḥ	linked with / accompanied by
tadviparītaḥ	the opposite of that (superior method)
śreyān	better / superior
vyaktā	the manifest (the 23 evolutes)
avyakta	the unmanifest (Prakriti)
jña	the knower (Purusha)
vijñānāt	from the discriminative knowledge

Verse 3: The 25 Principles (Tattvas)

Sanskrit Text

mūlaprakṛtir avikṛtir mahadādyāḥ prakṛti-vikṛtayaḥ sapta |
ṣoḍaśakas tu vikāro na prakṛtir na vikṛtiḥ puruṣaḥ ||

English Translation

Root Nature (Prakriti) is not a modification (it is uncreated). The seven principles beginning with the Intellect (Mahat) are both modifications and producers. The group of sixteen are only modifications. Purusha (Consciousness) is neither a producer nor a modification.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
mūlaprakṛtiḥ	Root Nature / Original Matter
avikṛtiḥ	not a modification / uncreated
mahadādyāḥ	Intellect (Mahat) and the rest
prakṛti	producer / cause
vikṛtayah	modifications / effects
sapta	seven
ṣoḍaśakas	group of sixteen
tu	but / indeed
vikāro	modifications (only effects)
na prakṛtir	not a producer / not nature
na vikṛtiḥ	not a modification / not created
puruṣaḥ	Consciousness / The Witness

Verse 4: The Three Means of Valid Knowledge (Pramanas)

Sanskrit Text

dr̥ṣṭam anumānam āptavacanam ca, sarvapramāṇasiddhatvāt |
trividham pramāṇam iṣṭam, prameyasiddhiḥ pramāṇād dhi ||

English Translation

The means of valid knowledge are accepted as threefold: direct perception, inference, and valid testimony, because all other means of knowledge are established in these. Indeed, the proof of an object to be known depends on the means of valid knowledge.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dr̥ṣṭam	seen / direct perception
anumānam	inference
āptavacanam	trustworthy word / valid testimony
ca	and
sarva	all
pramāṇa	means of knowledge
siddhatvāt	because of being established
trividham	threefold
pramāṇam	means of valid knowledge
iṣṭam	accepted / desired
prameya	object to be known

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
siddhiḥ	proof / establishment
pramāṇāt	from the means of knowledge
hi	indeed

Verse 5: Definition of the Pramanas

Sanskrit Text

pratiṣayādhyavasāyo dṛṣṭaṁ, trividham anumānam ākhyātam |
talliṅgaliṅgipūrvakam, āptaśrutir āptavacanam tu ||

English Translation

Direct perception is the ascertainment of specific objects (through the senses). Inference is declared to be of three kinds, and it is preceded by the knowledge of the characteristic mark (linga) and that which bears the mark (lingi). Valid testimony is the true revelation (Shruti) and trustworthy words.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pratiṣaya	with regard to specific objects
adhyavasāyaḥ	ascertainment / determination
dṛṣṭaṁ	perception
trividham	threefold
anumānam	inference
ākhyātam	is declared
tad	that (inference)
liṅga	characteristic mark / sign
liṅgi	that which bears the mark
pūrvakam	preceded by
āptaśrutir	trustworthy revelation / text
āptavacanam	trustworthy word
tu	and / indeed

Verse 6: Imperceptible Objects and Inference

Sanskrit Text

sāmānyatas tu dṛṣṭād atīndriyāṇāṁ pratītir anumānāt |
tasmād api cāsiddham parokṣam āptāgamāt siddham ||

English Translation

Knowledge of things beyond the senses is attained through inference based on general correlation. But that which is imperceptible and cannot be established even by that inference is established by valid testimony or trustworthy texts.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sāmānyataḥ	based on general correlation
tu	but / indeed
dr̥ṣṭāt	from observation
atīndriyāṇām	of things beyond the senses
pratītiḥ	knowledge / understanding
anumānāt	from inference
tasmāt	from that
api	even
ca	and
asiddham	unestablished / unproved
parokṣam	imperceptible / remote
āptāgamāt	from trustworthy texts / tradition
siddham	is established

Verse 7: Causes of Non-Perception

Sanskrit Text

atidūrāt sāmīpyād indriyaghātān mano'navasthānāt |
sūkṣmyād vyavadhānāt abhibhavāt samānābhihārāc ca ||

English Translation

An object may be unperceived due to extreme distance, extreme proximity, injury to the sense organs, non-steadiness of the mind, extreme subtlety, obstruction, being overpowered, or being mixed with similar objects.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
atidūrāt	from extreme distance
sāmīpyāt	from extreme proximity
indriyaghātāt	from injury to the senses
manaḥ	mind
anavasthānāt	from unsteadiness / distraction
sūkṣmyāt	from subtlety
vyavadhānāt	from obstruction / interposition

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
abhibhavāt	from being overpowered (like stars by the sun)
samānābhīhārāt	from being mixed with similar things
ca	and

Verse 8: Non-Perception of Prakriti

Sanskrit Text

saukṣmyāt tadanupalabdhir nābhāvāt, kāryatas tadupalabdhīḥ |
mahadādi tac ca kāryaṁ, prakṛtisvarūpaṁ virūpaṁ ca ||

English Translation

The non-perception of Prakriti is due to its subtlety, not because of its non-existence. Its perception is through its effects. Its effects are Mahat (Intellect) and the rest, which are both similar and dissimilar to Prakriti.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
saukṣmyāt	due to subtlety
tad	its (Prakriti's)
anupalabdhīḥ	non-perception
na	not
abhāvāt	due to non-existence
kāryataḥ	from its effect
tad	its
upalabdhīḥ	perception / apprehension
mahadādi	intellect (Mahat) and the rest
tac	that
ca	and
kāryaṁ	effect
prakṛtisvarūpaṁ	similar in nature to Prakriti
virūpaṁ	dissimilar
ca	and

Verse 9: The Theory of Pre-existent Effect (Satkaryavada)

Sanskrit Text

asadakaraṇād upādānagrahaṇāt sarvasambhavābhāvāt |

śaktasya śakyakaraṇāt kāraṇabhāvāc ca satkāryam ||

English Translation

The effect is pre-existent in the cause (Satkaryavada), because what is non-existent cannot be produced; because a specific material cause is required; because everything cannot be produced from everything; because a potent cause can only produce what it is capable of; and because the effect is of the same nature as the cause.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
asat	non-existent
akaraṇāt	from not being able to be produced
upādāna	material cause
grahaṇāt	from the selection / necessity of taking
sarva	all / everything
sambhava	production / arising
abhāvāt	from the absence
śaktasya	of the capable / potent (cause)
śakyakaraṇāt	from producing what is possible
kāraṇabhāvāt	from the nature of the cause
ca	and
satkāryam	the effect exists (before its manifestation)

Verse 10: Characteristics of the Manifest and Unmanifest

Sanskrit Text

hetumat anityam avyāpi sakriyam anekam āśritam liṅgam |
sāvayavaṁ paratantraṁ vyaktaṁ viparītam avyaktam ||

English Translation

The manifest (Vyakta) is caused, impermanent, non-pervasive, active, manifold, dependent, serving as a mark, composed of parts, and subordinate. The unmanifest (Avyakta) is the reverse of these.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
hetumat	having a cause

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
anityam	impermanent
avyāpi	non-pervasive / limited
sakriyam	active
anekam	manifold / many
āśritaṁ	dependent / supported
liṅgam	serving as a mark / characteristic
sāvayavaṁ	composed of parts
paratantraṁ	subordinate / dependent
vyaktaṁ	the manifest
viparītaṁ	the reverse / opposite
avyaktaṁ	the unmanifest

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 2

(Verses 11-20)

Continuing the exploration of Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, this second volume breaks down verses 11 through 20. These verses elaborate on the qualities of the Manifest and Unmanifest, define the three Gunas (Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas), establish the existence of Prakriti and Purusha, and outline the plurality of Purushas.

Verse 11: Nature of the Manifest and Unmanifest

Sanskrit Text

triguṇam aviveki viśayaḥ sāmānyam acetanaṁ prasavadharmi |
vyaktaṁ tathā pradhānam, tadviparītas tathā ca pumān ||

English Translation

The manifest (Vyakta) is composed of the three gunas, is indiscriminate, objective, common, non-conscious, and prolific. So is the Pradhana (Prakriti). The Purusha (Consciousness) is the reverse of these, yet also similar in some respects.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
triguṇam	composed of the three gunas
aviveki	indiscriminate / non-distinguishing

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
viṣayaḥ	objective / object of experience
sāmānyam	common / universal
acetanaṁ	non-conscious / insentient
prasavadharmi	prolific / productive
vyaktaṁ	the manifest
tathā	similarly / so
pradhānam	Pradhana / Root Prakriti
tadviparītas	the reverse of that / opposite
tathā ca	and yet similar
pumān	Purusha / Spirit

Verse 12: The Nature of the Three Gunas

Sanskrit Text

prītyaprītiviṣādātmakāḥ prakāśapravṛttinīyamārthāḥ |
anyonyābhibhavāśrayajananamaithunavṛttayaś ca guṇāḥ ||

English Translation

The gunas are of the nature of pleasure (Sattva), pain (Rajas), and delusion/heaviness (Tamas). They serve the purposes of illumination, activity, and restraint. They function by mutually subduing, supporting, producing, and consorting with one another.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
prīti	pleasure / joy (Sattva)
aprīti	pain / distress (Rajas)
viṣāda	delusion / dullness (Tamas)
ātmakāḥ	whose nature is
prakāśa	illumination / clarity
pravṛtti	activity / movement
niyama	restraint / inertia
arthāḥ	for the purpose of
anyonya	mutual / one another
abhibhava	subduing / overpowering

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
āśraya	supporting / depending on
janana	producing / generating
maithuna	consorting / mixing together
vṛttayaś	functioning / acting
ca	and
guṇāḥ	the threads / qualities

Verse 13: Characteristics of Sattva, Rajas, and Tamas

Sanskrit Text

sattvaṁ laghu prakāśakam iṣṭam upaṣṭambhakam calaṁ ca rajaḥ |
guru varaṇakam eva tamaḥ pradīpavaccārthato vṛttiḥ ||

English Translation

Sattva is buoyant and illuminating; Rajas is stimulating and mobile; Tamas is heavy and enveloping. Their functioning is for a single purpose, much like a lamp (which works through the combination of oil, wick, and fire).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sattvaṁ	Sattva
laghu	buoyant / light
prakāśakam	illuminating
iṣṭam	is considered / desired
upaṣṭambhakam	stimulating / exciting
calaṁ	mobile / unsteady
ca	and
rajaḥ	Rajas
guru	heavy
varaṇakam	enveloping / obscuring
eva	indeed
tamaḥ	Tamas
pradīpavat	like a lamp

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ca	and
arthato	for a single purpose
vṛttiḥ	functioning / action

Verse 14: Proof of the Unmanifest Cause

Sanskrit Text

avivekyādiḥ siddhas traiguṇyāt tadviparyayābhāvāt |
kāraṇaguṇātmatmakatvāt kāryasyāvyaktam api siddham ||

English Translation

Indiscriminateness and the rest are established from the existence of the three gunas, and from the absence of their reverse. The unmanifest is also established, because the effect must possess the nature of the cause.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
avivekyādiḥ	indiscriminateness and the rest
siddhas	are established / proved
traiguṇyāt	from the three gunas

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tadviparyayābhāvāt	from the absence of their reverse
kāraṇaguṇātmakatvāt	because the effect has the qualities of the cause
kāryasya	of the effect
avyaktam	the unmanifest
api	also
siddham	is established

Verse 15: Reasons for the Existence of Avyakta (Prakriti)

Sanskrit Text

bhedānāṃ parimāṇāt samanvayāt śaktiḥ pravṛtteśca |
kāraṇakāryavibhāgād avibhāgād vaiśvarūpyasya ||

English Translation

The Unmanifest cause exists because of the finite nature of specific objects, because of their homogeneity, because evolution is driven by power, because of the separation between cause and effect, and because of the non-separation (merging) of the entire universe back into its source.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
bhedānām	of specific objects / differences
parimāṇāt	from the finite nature / measurement
samanvayāt	from homogeneity / coordination
śaktiḥ	through power / capability
pravṛtteśca	and from evolution / activity
kāraṇakāryavibhāgād	from the separation of cause and effect
avibhāgād	from the non-separation / reunion
vaiśvarūpyasya	of the entire universe / multiformity

Verse 16: Functioning of the Unmanifest

Sanskrit Text

kāraṇam asty avyaktaṁ pravartate triguṇataḥ samudayācca |
pariṇāmataḥ salilavat pratipratiguṇāśrayaviśeṣāt ||

English Translation

The Unmanifest cause exists and functions through the three gunas and their combination. It is

modified like water, according to the specific nature resting in each respective guna.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
kāraṇam	the cause
asty	exists
avyaktaṁ	the unmanifest
pravartate	functions / operates
triguṇataḥ	through the three gunas
samudayācca	and by combination / aggregation
pariṇāmataḥ	by modification / transformation
salilavat	like water
pratiprati	each respective
guṇāśraya	resting in the guna
viśeṣāt	due to specific nature / difference

Verse 17: Proof of Purusha (Consciousness)

Sanskrit Text

sanghāta-parārthatvāt triguṇādi-viparyayāt adhiṣṭhānāt |
puruṣo'sti bhoktṛbhāvāt kaivalyārtham pravṛtteś ca ||

English Translation

Purusha exists because all combinations of matter are for the sake of another; because it must be the opposite of the three gunas; because there must be a supervisor (controller); because there must be an experiencer; and because of the inherent tendency toward liberation.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sanghāta	assemblages / combinations of matter
parārthatvāt	because of being for another's purpose
triguṇādi	the three gunas, etc.
viparyayāt	because of being the reverse / opposite
adhiṣṭhānāt	because of control / supervision
puruṣo'sti	Purusha exists
bhoktṛbhāvāt	because of the nature of being an

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
	experiencer
kaivalyārtham	for the purpose of liberation
pravṛtteś	because of the activity / tendency
ca	and

Verse 18: Plurality of Purushas

Sanskrit Text

jananamaraṇākaraṇānāṁ pratiniyamād ayugapatpravṛtteśca |
puruṣabahutvaṁ siddhaṁ traiguṇyaviparyayāccaiva ||

English Translation

The multiplicity of Purushas is established from the individual allotment of birth, death, and the instruments (of cognition and action); from the non-simultaneous nature of activities; and indeed from the diverse modifications of the three gunas.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
janana	birth
maraṇa	death

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
karaṇānām	of the instruments / organs
pratiniyamād	from individual allotment / regulation
ayugapat	non-simultaneous
pravṛtteśca	and from activity
puruṣabahutvaṁ	multiplicity of Purushas
siddhaṁ	is established
traiguṇyaviparyayāt	from the diverse modifications of the three gunas
ca eva	and indeed

Verse 19: Characteristics of Purusha

Sanskrit Text

tasmāc ca viparyāsāt siddhaṁ sākṣitvam asya puruṣasya |
kaivalyaṁ mādhyasthyaṁ draṣṭṛtvam akartṛbhāvaśca ||

English Translation

And from that contrast (to Prakriti), it is established that this Purusha is the witness, isolated,

neutral, the seer, and the non-doer.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tasmāc	therefore
ca	and
viparyāsāt	from that contrast / reverse
siddham	is established
sākṣitvam	the nature of being a witness
asya	of this
puruṣasya	of Purusha
kaivalyaṁ	isolation / absolute freedom
mādhyasthyaṁ	neutrality
draṣṭṛtvam	the nature of being a seer
akartṛbhāvaśca	and the nature of being a non-doer

Verse 20: The Illusion of Agency and Consciousness

Sanskrit Text

tasmāt tatsaṁyogād acetanaṁ cetanāvad iva liṅgam |
guṇakartṛtve ca tathā karteḥ bhavaty udāsīnaḥ ||

English Translation

Therefore, from their conjunction, the non-conscious evolute (Intellect) appears as if it were conscious; and similarly, though the gunas are the agents of action, the indifferent Purusha appears as if it were the agent.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tasmāt	therefore
tatsaṁyogād	from their conjunction / association
acetanaṁ	the non-conscious
cetanāvad	like the conscious
iva	as if
liṅgam	the evolute / sign (Intellect)
guṇakartṛtve	while the gunas are the agents

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ca	and
tathā	similarly
karteva	as if the agent
bhavaty	becomes
udāsīnaḥ	the indifferent one (Purusha)

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 3

(Verses 21-30)

Continuing the exploration of Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, this third volume breaks down verses 21 through 30. These verses are crucial for understanding the evolutionary process of creation (Sarga), starting from the purpose of the union between Purusha and Prakriti, down through the emergence of the Intellect (Mahat), Ego (Ahamkara), Mind (Manas), the senses, and their respective functions.

Verse 21: The Purpose of Conjunction (Creation)

Sanskrit Text

puruṣasya darśanārthaṁ kaivalyārthaṁ tathā pradhānasya |
paṅgvandhavad ubhayor api saṁyogas tatkr̥taḥ sargaḥ ||

English Translation

For the Purusha's contemplation of Prakriti, and for his liberation, the conjunction of both takes place, like that of a lame man and a blind man. By that conjunction, creation is brought about.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
puruṣasya	of the Purusha
darśanārthaṁ	for the purpose of seeing/experiencing

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
kaivalyārthaṁ	for the purpose of liberation
tathā	likewise / so
pradhānasya	of Pradhana / Prakriti
paṅgvandhavad	like the lame and the blind
ubhayaṃ	of both
api	also / indeed
saṁyogas	conjunction / union
tatkṛtaḥ	made by that / caused by that
sargaḥ	creation / evolution

Verse 22: The Order of Evolution (Sarga)

Sanskrit Text

prakṛter mahāṁs tato'haṅkāras tasmād gaṇaś ca ṣoḍaśakaḥ |
tasmād api ṣoḍaśakāt pañcabhyaḥ pañca bhūtāni ||

English Translation

From Prakriti emerges the Intellect (Mahat); from that, the Ego (Ahamkara); from that, the

group of sixteen (the 11 senses and 5 subtle elements); and from five of those sixteen (the subtle elements), the five gross elements.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
prakṛter	from Prakriti (Root Nature)
mahāns	the Great One (Mahat / Intellect)
tato	from that (Mahat)
'haṅkāras	Ahamkara (Ego / I-maker)
tasmād	from that (Ahamkara)
gaṇaś	the group
ca	and
ṣoḍaśakaḥ	of sixteen
tasmād	from that
api	further
ṣoḍaśakāt	from the sixteen

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pañcabhyaḥ	from the five (subtle elements)
pañca	the five
bhūtāni	gross elements

Verse 23: The Nature and Forms of Intellect (Buddhi)

Sanskrit Text

adhyavasāyo buddhir dharmo jñānaṁ virāga aiśvaryaṁ |
sāttvikam etadrūpaṁ tāmasam asmād viparyastam ||

English Translation

The Intellect (Buddhi) is ascertainment (determination). Virtue, knowledge, non-attachment, and power are its Sattvic forms; its Tamasic forms are the reverse of these.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
adhyavasāyo	ascertainment / determination
buddhir	Intellect
dharmo	virtue / duty

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
jñānaṁ	knowledge
virāga	non-attachment / dispassion
aiśvaryaṁ	power / sovereignty
sāttvikam	Sattvic (pure / luminous)
etadrūpaṁ	its forms
tāmasam	Tamasic (dark / heavy)
asmād	from this
viparyastam	reversed / opposite

Verse 24: The Nature of Ego (Ahamkara)

Sanskrit Text

abhimāno'haṅkāras tasmād dvidvidhaḥ pravartate sargaḥ |
ekādaśakaś ca gaṇas tanmātrapañcakaṁ caiva ||

English Translation

The Ego (Ahamkara) is self-conceit (arrogation). From it proceeds a twofold creation: the group of eleven (senses) and the five subtle elements (Tanmatras).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
abhimāno	self-conceit / I-sense / arrogation
'haṅkāras	Ahamkara (Ego)
tasmād	from that
dvividhaḥ	twofold
pravartate	proceeds
sargaḥ	creation
ekādaśakaś	the group of eleven
ca	and
gaṇas	group
tanmātrapañcakam	the five subtle elements
caiva	and indeed

Verse 25: The Threefold Nature of Ahamkara

Sanskrit Text

sāttvika ekādaśakaḥ pravartate vaikṛtād ahaṅkāṛāt |
bhūtādes tanmātraḥ sa tāmasas taijasād ubhayam ||

English Translation

The Sattvic group of eleven senses proceeds from the Vaikrita (Sattvic) Ahamkara. The group of five subtle elements proceeds from the Bhutadi (Tamasic) Ahamkara. Both proceed with the help of the Taijasa (Rajasic) Ahamkara.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sāttvika	Sattvic (pure)
ekādaśakaḥ	group of eleven (organs/senses)
pravartate	proceeds
vaikṛtād	from the Vaikrita (modified/Sattvic)
ahaṅkāṛāt	from Ahamkara
bhūtādes	from the Bhutadi (origin of elements/Tamasic)
tanmātraḥ	the subtle elements
sa	that

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tāmasas	Tamasic (dark/heavy)
taijasād	from the Taijasa (luminous/active/Rajasic)
ubhayam	both

Verse 26: The Organs of Perception and Action

Sanskrit Text

buddhīndriyāṇi cakṣuḥ śrotra-ghrāṇa-rasana-tvagākhyāni |
vāk-pāṇi-pāda-pāyūpasthān karmendriyāṇy āhuḥ ||

English Translation

The organs of perception (Buddhindriyas) are called the eyes, ears, nose, tongue, and skin. Voice, hands, feet, the excretory organ, and the generative organ are said to be the organs of action (Karmendriyas).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
buddhīndriyāṇi	organs of perception / intellect
cakṣuḥ	eyes
śrotra	ears

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ghrāṇa	nose
rasana	tongue
tvag	skin
ākhyāni	are called
vāk	voice / speech
pāṇi	hands
pāda	feet
pāyu	excretory organ
upasthān	generative organ
karmendriyāṇy	organs of action
āhuḥ	they say / are said to be

Verse 27: The Nature of the Mind (Manas)

Sanskrit Text

ubhayātmakam atra manaḥ saṅkalpakam indriyaṁ ca sādharmaṃ |

guṇapariṇāmaviśeṣān nānātvam bāhyabhedās ca ||

English Translation

Here, the Mind (Manas) is of the nature of both (perception and action). It is the deliberating faculty, and it is a sense organ due to its affinity with the rest. The multiplicity of organs and their external differences are due to the specific modifications of the gunas.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ubhayātmakam	of the nature of both (perception and action)
atra	here
manaḥ	mind
saṅkalpakam	deliberating / pondering
indriyam	sense organ
ca	and
sādharmyāt	due to similarity / affinity
guṇa	gunas (Sattva, Rajas, Tamas)
pariṇāma	modification

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
viśeṣān	due to specifics
nānātvam	multiplicity / variety
bāhya	external
bhedās	differences
ca	and

Verse 28: Functions of the Senses

Sanskrit Text

rūpādiṣu pañcānām ālocanamātram iṣyate vṛttiḥ |
vacanādānaviharaṇotsargānandās ca pañcānām ||

English Translation

The function of the five (organs of perception) is considered to be merely witnessing (perceiving) form/color and the other sense objects. Speaking, grasping, walking, excreting, and experiencing joy are the functions of the other five (organs of action).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
rūpādiṣu	regarding form/color and the rest

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pañcānām	of the five (organs of perception)
ālocana	witnessing / observing / bare perception
mātram	merely / only
iṣyate	is considered / desired
vṛttiḥ	function
vacana	speaking
ādāna	grasping
vihaṛaṇa	walking / moving
utsarga	excreting
ānandās	joy / bliss (sexual function)
ca	and
pañcānām	of the (other) five (organs of action)

Verse 29: Functions of the Internal Organs and Pranas

Sanskrit Text

svālakṣaṇyaṁ vṛttis trayasya saiṣā bhavaty asāmānyā |
sāmānyakaraṇavṛttiḥ prāṇādyā vāyavaḥ pañca ||

English Translation

The specific characteristics of the three (internal organs: Intellect, Ego, Mind) constitute their respective uncommon functions. Their common function is the circulation of the five vital airs (Prana, etc.).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
svālakṣaṇyaṁ	own specific characteristic
vṛttis	function
trayasya	of the three (internal organs)
saiṣā	that very
bhavaty	is / becomes
asāmānyā	uncommon / extraordinary
sāmānya	common
karaṇa	instrument / organ

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
vṛttiḥ	function
prāṇādyā	Prana and the rest (vital airs)
vāyavaḥ	winds / airs
pañca	five

Verse 30: Simultaneous and Sequential Functioning

Sanskrit Text

yugapac catuṣṭayasya tu vṛttiḥ kramaśaś ca tasya nirdiṣṭā |
 dr̥ṣṭe tathāpy adr̥ṣṭe trayasya tatpūrvikā vṛttiḥ ||

English Translation

With regard to visible objects, the functions of the four (the three internal organs plus one external sense) may occur simultaneously or sequentially. With regard to unseen objects, the function of the three (internal organs) is preceded by that (prior perception).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
yugapac	simultaneously
catuṣṭayasya	of the four (3 internal + 1 external organ)

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tu	but / indeed
vṛttiḥ	function
kramaśaś	sequentially
ca	and
tasya	of that
nirdiṣṭā	is indicated / declared
drṣṭe	regarding the seen / visible objects
tathāpy	so also / nevertheless
adrṣṭe	regarding the unseen / invisible objects
trayasya	of the three (internal organs)
tat	that
pūrvikā	preceded by
vṛttiḥ	function

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 4

(Verses 31-40)

This fourth volume continues the deep dive into Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, covering verses 31 through 40. These verses map the operations of the sensory and action organs, define the hierarchy between the internal and external instruments (karana), detail how the intellect illuminates experience for Purusha, and introduce the concept of the transmigrating subtle body (Linga Sarira).

Verse 31: The Spontaneous Functioning of Organs

Sanskrit Text

svām svām pratipadyante parasparākūtavetukām vṛttim |
puruṣārtha eva hetur na kenacit kāryate karaṇam ||

English Translation

The organs perform their own respective functions incited by mutual impulse. The purpose of Purusha (Consciousness) is the sole cause; an organ is not made to act by anyone else.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
svām svām	their own respective
pratipadyante	they perform / they undertake

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
parasparākūtavetukām	incited by mutual impulse / intention
vṛttim	function
puruṣārtha	the purpose of Purusha
eva	alone / indeed
hetur	the cause
na	not
kenacit	by anyone
kāryate	is made to act
karaṇam	the instrument / organ

Verse 32: The Thirteen Instruments and Their Objects

Sanskrit Text

karaṇaṁ trayodaśavidhaṁ tad āharaṇadhāraṇaprakāśakaram |
kāryaṁ ca tasya daśadhā hāryaṁ dhāryaṁ prakāśyaṁ ca ||

English Translation

The instrument (Karana) is of thirteen kinds (intellect, ego, mind, and the ten senses). It

performs the functions of seizing, retaining, and illuminating. Its object is of ten kinds, namely, what is to be seized, retained, and illuminated.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
karaṇaṁ	the instrument
trayodaśavidhaṁ	of thirteen kinds
tad	that
āharaṇa	seizing
dhāraṇa	retaining
prakāśakaram	illuminating
kāryaṁ	the object / function
ca	and
tasya	its
daśadhā	of ten kinds
hāryaṁ	what is to be seized

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dhāryaṁ	what is to be retained
prakāśyaṁ	what is to be illuminated
ca	and

Verse 33: Internal and External Organs in Time

Sanskrit Text

antaḥkaraṇaṁ trividhaṁ daśadhā bāhyaṁ trayasya viṣayākhyam |
sāmpratakālaṁ bāhyaṁ trikālaṁ ābhyantaraṁ karaṇam ||

English Translation

The internal organ is threefold (Intellect, Ego, Mind). The external is tenfold and forms the objects of those three. The external organ functions in the present time; the internal organ functions in all three times (past, present, and future).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
antaḥkaraṇaṁ	the internal organ
trividhaṁ	threefold
daśadhā	tenfold

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
bāhyaṁ	the external
trayasya	of the three
viṣayākhyam	called the object
sāmpratakālaṁ	in the present time
bāhyaṁ	the external
trikālam	in the three times (past, present, future)
ābhyantaram	the internal
karaṇam	organ / instrument

Verse 34: Specific and Non-Specific Objects of the Senses

Sanskrit Text

buddhīndriyāṇi teṣāṁ pañca viśeṣāviśeṣaviṣayāṇi |
vāgbhavati śabdaviṣayā śeṣāṇi tu pañcaviṣayāṇi ||

English Translation

Among them, the five organs of perception have both specific (gross) and non-specific (subtle) objects. Speech has only sound for its object, but the rest (of the action organs) have all five as

their objects.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
buddhīndriyāṇi	the organs of perception
teṣāṃ	among them
pañca	the five
viśeṣāviśeṣaviśayāṇi	having specific and non-specific objects
vāk	speech
bhavati	is
śabdaviśayā	having sound as its object
śeṣāṇi	the rest
tu	but
pañcaviśayāṇi	having all five as objects

Verse 35: Intellect as the Principal Gatekeeper

Sanskrit Text

sāntaḥkaraṇā buddhiḥ sarvaṁ viṣayam avagāhate yasmāt |
tasmāt trividhaṁ karaṇaṁ dvāri dvārāṇi śeṣāṇi ||

English Translation

Since the Intellect (Buddhi), together with the other internal organs (Ego and Mind), comprehends every object, therefore the threefold internal organ is the principal gatekeeper, and the rest (the external senses) are merely the gates.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sāntaḥkaraṇā	together with the internal organs
buddhiḥ	Intellect
sarvaṁ	every
viṣayam	object
avagāhate	comprehends / plunges into
yasmāt	since
tasmāt	therefore
trividhaṁ	threefold
karaṇaṁ	instrument

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dvāri	the principal / gatekeeper
dvārāṇi	the gates
śeṣāṇi	the rest

Verse 36: Organs Resembling a Lamp

Sanskrit Text

ete pradīpakalpāḥ parasparavilakṣaṇā guṇaviśeṣāḥ |
kṛtsnam puruṣasyārtham prakāśya buddhau prayacchanti ||

English Translation

These organs, which are characteristically different from one another and are specific modifications of the gunas, resemble a lamp. Having illuminated the entire purpose of the Purusha, they present it to the Intellect (Buddhi).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ete	these
pradīpakalpāḥ	resembling a lamp
parasparavilakṣaṇā	characteristically different from one another

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
guṇaviśeṣāḥ	specific modifications of the gunas
kṛtsnam	the entire
puruṣasyārtham	purpose of the Purusha
prakāśya	having illuminated
buddhau	to the Intellect
prayacchanti	they present / give

Verse 37: The Ultimate Function of Buddhi

Sanskrit Text

sarvaṁ pratyupabhogam yasmāt puruṣasya sādhayati buddhiḥ |
saiva ca viśiṇaṣṭi punaḥ pradhānapuruṣāntaram sūkṣmam ||

English Translation

Since it is the Intellect (Buddhi) that accomplishes all enjoyment for the Purusha, it is also that very Intellect which ultimately distinguishes the subtle difference between Pradhana (Prakriti) and Purusha.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sarvaṁ	all
pratyupabhogam	enjoyment / experience
yasmāt	since
puruṣasya	of the Purusha
sādhayati	accomplishes / brings about
buddhiḥ	Intellect
saiva	that very
ca	and
viśiṇaṣṭi	distinguishes
punaḥ	again / further
pradhānapuruṣāntaram	the difference between Pradhana and Purusha
sūkṣmam	subtle

Verse 38: Subtle and Gross Elements

Sanskrit Text

tanmātrāṇy aviśeṣās tebhyo bhūtāni pañca pañcabhyaḥ |
ete smṛtā viśeṣāḥ śāntā ghorās ca mūḍhās ca ||

English Translation

The subtle elements (Tanmatras) are non-specific (un-diversified). From those five proceed the five gross elements. These gross elements are known as specific (diversified), and they are tranquil, terrifying, and deluding.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tanmātrāṇy	the subtle elements
aviśeṣās	non-specific / un-diversified
tebhyo	from those
bhūtāni	the elements
pañca	five
pañcabhyaḥ	from the five
ete	these

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
smṛtā	are known / considered
viśeṣāḥ	specific / diversified
śāntā	tranquil / soothing (Sattvic)
ghorāś	terrifying / turbulent (Rajasic)
ca	and
mūḍhāś	deluding / stupefying (Tamasic)
ca	and

Verse 39: Three Kinds of Specific Entities

Sanskrit Text

sūkṣmā mātāpitṛjāḥ saha prabhūtais tridhā viśeṣāḥ syuḥ |
sūkṣmās teṣāṃ niyatā mātāpitṛjā nivartante ||

English Translation

The specific entities are of three kinds: subtle bodies, those born of parents (gross physical bodies), and the gross elements themselves. Of these, the subtle bodies are constant, while those born of parents are perishable.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sūkṣmā	subtle bodies
mātāpitṛjāḥ	born of parents (gross bodies)
saha	together with
prabhūtais	the gross elements
tridhā	of three kinds
viśeṣāḥ	specific entities
syuḥ	are
sūkṣmās	the subtle ones
teṣāṃ	among them
niyatā	constant / permanent
mātāpitṛjā	those born of parents
nivartante	perish / turn away

Verse 40: The Transmigrating Subtle Body (Linga)

Sanskrit Text

pūrvotpannam asaktam niyatam mahadādi-sūkṣmabhūtaparyantam |
saṁsarati nirupabhogaṁ bhāvair adhivāsitaṁ liṅgam ||

English Translation

The subtle body (Linga), previously formed, unattached, and constant, composed of principles starting from Mahat (Intellect) down to the subtle elements, migrates. Being devoid of experience itself, it is invested with dispositions (Bhavas).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pūrvotpannam	previously formed (at the beginning of creation)
asaktam	unattached / unconfined
niyatam	constant
mahadādi-sūkṣmabhūtaparyantam	from Mahat down to the subtle elements
saṁsarati	migrates / transmigrates
nirupabhogaṁ	devoid of experience itself
bhāvair	with dispositions / conditions
adhivāsitaṁ	invested / perfumed / colored

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
liṅgam	the subtle body / characteristic mark

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 5 (Verses 41-50)

Continuing our comprehensive study of Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, this fifth volume breaks down verses 41 through 50. These verses elaborate on the necessity of the subtle body, the nature of the various dispositions (Bhavas), the eightfold path of consequences, and the detailed categorization of intellectual creations (Pratyayasarga) including ignorance, incapacity, complacency, and perfection.

Verse 41: The Support of the Subtle Body

Sanskrit Text

citraṁ yathāśrayam ṛte sthāṇvādibhyo vinā yathā chāyā |
tadvad vinā viśeṣair na tiṣṭhati nirāśrayaṁ līṅgam ||

English Translation

As a picture does not exist without a support, or as a shadow does not exist without a solid object like a post, similarly the subtle body (Linga) does not exist unsupported without specific (gross) elements.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
citraṁ	a picture / painting
yathā	as
āśrayam ṛte	without a support / canvas
sthāṇvādibhyo vinā	without a post and the rest
yathā	as
chāyā	a shadow
tadvad	similarly / in that way
vinā viśeṣair	without specific (gross) elements
na tiṣṭhati	does not stand / does not exist
nirāśrayaṁ	without support / ungrounded
līṅgam	the subtle body

Verse 42: The Action of the Subtle Body

Sanskrit Text

puruṣārthahetukam idaṁ nimittanaimittikaprasaṅgena |
prakṛter vibhutvayogān naṭavad vyavatiṣṭhate līṅgam ||

English Translation

For the sake of Puruṣa's purpose, the subtle body acts through the connection of means and ends (causes and effects). Through connection with the all-pervading power of Prakṛti, it plays various roles like an actor.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
puruṣārthahetukam	motivated by Puruṣa's purpose
idaṁ	this
nimittanaimittikaprasaṅgena	through the connection of causes and effects (means and ends)
prakṛter	of Prakṛti
vibhutvayogān	due to connection with the all-pervading power
naṭavad	like an actor
vyavatiṣṭhate	acts / plays roles / behaves
līṅgam	the subtle body

Verse 43: Dispositions (Bhavas) and their Supports

Sanskrit Text

sāṃsiddhikāś ca bhāvāḥ prākṛtikā vaikṛtikāś ca dharmādyāḥ |
dṛṣṭāḥ karaṇāśrayiṇaḥ kāryāśrayiṇaś ca kalalādyāḥ ||

English Translation

The dispositions (Bhavas) like virtue (Dharma) and the rest are innate, natural, and acquired. They are seen as dependent on the instruments (the intellect), while the embryo and the rest are dependent on the effect (the gross body).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
sāṃsiddhikāś	innate / essential
ca	and
bhāvāḥ	dispositions / states
prākṛtikā	natural
vaikṛtikāś	acquired / modified
ca	and

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dharmādyāḥ	virtue and the rest
dr̥ṣṭāḥ	are seen / considered
karaṇāśrayiṇaḥ	dependent on the instruments (internal organs)
kāryāśrayiṇaś	dependent on the effect (gross body)
ca	and
kalalādyāḥ	the embryo and the rest

Verse 44: The Consequences of Dispositions (Part 1)

Sanskrit Text

dharmeṇa gamanam ūrdhvaṁ gamanam adho bhavaty adharmeṇa |
jñānena cāpavargo viparyayād iṣyate bandhaḥ ||

English Translation

By virtue (Dharma) there is ascent to higher regions; by vice (Adharma) there is descent to lower regions. By knowledge (Jnana) liberation is attained; by the reverse (ignorance), bondage is incurred.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dharmeṇa	by virtue / dharma
gamanam	going / ascent
ūrdhvaṁ	upward / to higher regions
gamanam	going / descent
adho	downward / to lower regions
bhavaty	becomes / happens
adharmeṇa	by vice / non-virtue
jñānena	by knowledge
cāpavargo	and liberation / emancipation
viparyayād	from the reverse (ignorance)
iṣyate	is considered / results in
bandhaḥ	bondage

Verse 45: The Consequences of Dispositions (Part 2)

Sanskrit Text

vairāgyāt prakṛtilayaḥ saṁsāro bhavati rāgāt |
aiśvaryād avighāto viparyayāt tadviparyāsaḥ ||

English Translation

From non-attachment (Vairagya) results absorption into Prakriti; from attachment (Raga) results transmigration. From power (Aishvarya) results non-obstruction; from the reverse results the opposite (obstruction).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
vairāgyāt	from non-attachment / dispassion
prakṛtilayaḥ	absorption into Prakriti
saṁsāro	transmigration / worldly existence
bhavati	becomes / results in
rāgāt	from attachment / passion
aiśvaryād	from power / mastery
avighāto	non-obstruction / freedom of will
viparyayāt	from the reverse (weakness)
tadviparyāsaḥ	the reverse of that (obstruction)

Verse 46: The Fifty Varieties of Intellectual Creation

Sanskrit Text

eṣa pratyayasargo viparyayāśaktituṣṭisiddhyākhyāḥ |
guṇavaiśamyavimardāt tasya ca bhedās tu pañcāśat ||

English Translation

This intellectual creation (Pratyayasarga) is termed ignorance, incapacity, complacency, and perfection. Due to the unequal suppression of the gunas, its varieties are fifty.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
eṣa	this
pratyayasargo	intellectual creation / mental evolution
viparyaya	ignorance / misconception
āśakti	incapacity / disability
tuṣṭi	complacency / contentment
siddhi	perfection / success
ākhyāḥ	called / termed
guṇavaiśamya	inequality of the gunas
vimardāt	from the suppression / clashing
tasya	its
ca	and

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
bhedās	varieties / divisions
tu	indeed
pañcāśat	fifty

Verse 47: The Subdivision of the Fifty Varieties

Sanskrit Text

pañcaviparyayabhedā bhavanty aśakteś ca karaṇavaikalyāt |
aṣṭāvimśatibhedās tuṣṭir navadhāṣṭadhā siddhiḥ ||

English Translation

There are five varieties of ignorance, and twenty-eight varieties of incapacity arising from defects of the organs. Complacency is of nine kinds, and perfection is of eight kinds.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pañcaviparyayabhedā	five varieties of ignorance
bhavanty	are
aśakteś	of incapacity
ca	and
karaṇavaikalyāt	from defect/impairment of organs
aṣṭāvimśatibhedās	twenty-eight varieties
tuṣṭir	complacency
navadhā	ninefold
aṣṭadhā	eightfold
siddhiḥ	perfection

Verse 48: The Five Varieties of Ignorance (Viparyaya)

Sanskrit Text

bhedas tamaso'ṣṭavidho mohasya ca daśavidho mahāmohaḥ |
tāmisro'ṣṭādaśadhā tathā bhavaty andhatāmisraḥ ||

English Translation

The variety of obscurity (Tamas) is eightfold, and so is delusion (Moha). Extreme delusion (Mahamoha) is tenfold. Gloom (Tamisra) is eighteenfold, and similarly, utter gloom (Andhatamisra) is eighteenfold.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
bhedas	variety / division
tamaso	of obscurity (Avidya)
'ṣṭavidho	eightfold
mohasya	of delusion (Asmita)
ca	and (also eightfold)
daśavidho	tenfold
mahāmohaḥ	extreme delusion (Raga)
tāmisro	gloom (Dvesha)
'ṣṭādaśadhā	eighteenfold
tathā	similarly
bhavaty	is
andhatāmisraḥ	utter gloom (Abhinivesha)

Verse 49: The Twenty-Eight Incapacities (Ashakti)

Sanskrit Text

ekādaśendriyavadhāḥ saha buddhivadhair aśaktir uddiṣṭā |
saptadaśavadhā buddher viparyayāt tuṣṭisiddhīnām ||

English Translation

The injuries of the eleven organs, together with the injuries of the intellect, are declared as incapacity. The injuries of the intellect are seventeen, arising from the inversion of the nine complacencies and eight perfections.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ekādaśa	eleven
indriyavadhāḥ	injuries of the organs
saha	together with
buddhivadhair	injuries of the intellect
aśaktir	incapacity
uddiṣṭā	is declared
saptadaśavadhā	seventeen injuries
buddher	of the intellect
viparyayāt	from the inversion / opposite
tuṣṭisiddhīnām	of complacencies and perfections

Verse 50: The Nine Complacencies (Tushti)

Sanskrit Text

ādhyātmikyaś catasraḥ prakṛtyupādānakālabhāgākhyāḥ |
bāhyā viṣayoparamāt pañca nava tuṣṭayo'bhimatāḥ ||

English Translation

The internal complacencies are four, named Nature (Prakriti), Means (Upadana), Time (Kala), and Luck (Bhaga). The external complacencies, resulting from abstention from the five objects of sense, are five. Thus, complacencies are accepted to be nine in total.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ādhyātmikyaś	internal (relating to the self)
catasraḥ	four
prakṛti	Nature
upādāna	Means
kāla	Time
bhāgākhyāḥ	named Luck / Destiny
bāhyā	external
viṣayoparamāt	from abstention of objects
pañca	five
nava	nine (in total)
tuṣṭayo	complacencies
'bhimatāḥ	are accepted / considered

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 6

(Verses 51-60)

This sixth volume continues our exploration of Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, covering verses 51 through 60. These verses detail the eight perfections, the mutual dependence of dispositions and the subtle body, the realms of creation, the nature of suffering, and several beautiful analogies explaining Prakriti's selfless activity for the liberation of Purusha.

Verse 51: The Eight Perfections (Siddhis)

Sanskrit Text

ūhaḥ śabdo'dhyayanam duḥkhavighātās trayāḥ suhṛtprāptiḥ |
dānam ca siddhayo'sṭau siddheḥ pūrvo'nkuśas trividhaḥ ||

English Translation

Reasoning, oral instruction, study, the removal of the three kinds of suffering, acquisition of friends, and purity (giving) are the eight perfections. The three previously mentioned (ignorance, incapacity, and complacency) serve as a threefold curb on perfection.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ūhaḥ	reasoning / contemplation
śabdo	word / oral instruction

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
'dhyayanam	study
duḥkhavighātās	removal of suffering
trayaḥ	the three (kinds)
suhṛtprāptiḥ	acquisition of friends (teachers/companions)
dānam	giving / charity / purity
ca	and
siddhayo	perfections
'ṣṭau	eight
siddheḥ	of perfection
pūrho	the previous (three classes)
'nkuśas	curb / hook / obstruction
trividhaḥ	threefold

Verse 52: Mutual Dependence of Disposition and

Subtle Body

Sanskrit Text

na vinā bhāvair liṅgaṁ na vinā liṅgena bhāvanirvṛttiḥ |
liṅgākhyo bhāvākhyas tasmād dvividhaḥ pravartate sargaḥ ||

English Translation

Without the dispositions (Bhavas) there is no subtle body (Linga); without the subtle body there is no formation of dispositions. Therefore, creation proceeds in a twofold manner, termed the creation of the subtle body and the creation of dispositions.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
na	not
vinā	without
bhāvair	dispositions / conditions
liṅgaṁ	the subtle body
na	not
vinā	without
liṅgena	the subtle body

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
bhāvanirvṛttiḥ	formation / manifestation of dispositions
līṅgākhyo	called the subtle body
bhāvākhyas	called the dispositions
tasmād	therefore
dvidvidhaḥ	twofold
pravartate	proceeds
sargaḥ	creation

Verse 53: The Realms of Gross Creation

Sanskrit Text

aṣṭavikalpo daivas tairyagyonaś ca pañcadhā bhavati |
mānuṣaś caikavidhaḥ samāsato bhautikaḥ sargaḥ ||

English Translation

The divine creation is of eight varieties; the animal creation is of five kinds; and the human creation is of one kind. This is, in brief, the elemental (gross) creation.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
aṣṭavikalpo	eight varieties
daivas	divine
tairyagyaṇaś	animal / lower creation
ca	and
pañcadhā	of five kinds
bhavati	is / becomes
mānuṣaś	human
ca	and
ekavidhaḥ	of one kind
saṁāsato	in brief / in summary
bhautikaḥ	elemental / gross
sargaḥ	creation

Verse 54: The Distribution of Gunas in Creation

Sanskrit Text

ūrdhvaṁ sattvaviśālas tamoviśālas tūmūlataḥ sargaḥ |
madhye rajoviśālo brahmādistambaparyantaḥ ||

English Translation

In the higher regions, Sattva prevails; in the lower creation (root-levels), Tamas prevails; in the middle (human realm), Rajas prevails. This is so from Brahma down to a blade of grass.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ūrdhvaṁ	above / in higher regions
sattvaviśālas	abounding in Sattva (purity/light)
tamoviśālas	abounding in Tamas (darkness/inertia)
tūmūlataḥ	at the root / in lower regions
sargaḥ	creation
madhye	in the middle
rajoviśālo	abounding in Rajas (activity/passion)
brahmādi	beginning with Brahma

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
stambaparyantaḥ	down to a blade of grass / pillar

Verse 55: The Nature of Suffering

Sanskrit Text

tatra jarāmaraṇakṛtaṁ duḥkhaṁ prāpnoti cetanaḥ puruṣaḥ |
liṅgasyāvinivṛttes tasmād duḥkhaṁ svabhāvena ||

English Translation

There (in these worlds), the conscious Purusha experiences suffering arising from decay and death. This lasts until the subtle body ceases to be; therefore, suffering is in the very nature of things.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tatra	there / in that creation
jarāmaraṇakṛtaṁ	arising from old age and death
duḥkhaṁ	suffering / pain
prāpnoti	attains / experiences
cetanaḥ	the conscious

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
puruṣaḥ	Purusha / Spirit
liṅgasya	of the subtle body
avinivṛttes	until the cessation
tasmād	therefore
duḥkhaṁ	suffering
svabhāvena	by its very nature / naturally

Verse 56: The Purpose of Prakriti's Evolution

Sanskrit Text

ityeṣa prakṛtikṛto mahadādiviśeṣabhūtaparyantaḥ |
 pratipuruṣavimokṣārthaṁ svārtha iva parārtha ārambhaḥ ||

English Translation

Thus, this creation, brought about by Prakriti, from the Intellect down to the specific gross elements, is for the deliverance of each individual Purusha. Though it is for the sake of another, she acts as if it were for her own benefit.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
iti	thus
eṣa	this
prakṛtikṛto	made by Prakriti
mahadādiviśeṣabhūtaparyantaḥ	from Intellect down to specific gross elements
pratipuruṣavimokṣārthaṁ	for the deliverance of each Purusha
svārtha	own benefit
iva	as if
parārtha	for another's benefit
ārambhaḥ	undertaking / creation

Verse 57: The Analogy of Milk and the Calf

Sanskrit Text

vatsavivṛddhinimittam kṣīrasya yathā pravṛttir ajñasya |
puruṣavimokṣanimittam tathā pravṛttiḥ pradhānasya ||

English Translation

Just as unintelligent milk functions for the nourishment of the calf, so does the Pradhana (Prakriti) function for the liberation of the Purusha.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
vatsavivṛddhinimittam	for the purpose of the calf's growth
kṣīrasya	of the milk
yathā	just as
pravṛttir	functioning / activity
ajñasya	of the non-intelligent
puruṣavimokṣanimittam	for the purpose of Purusha's liberation
tathā	so / in that way
pravṛttiḥ	functioning / activity
pradhānasya	of Pradhana / Prakriti

Verse 58: The Analogy of Relieving Desire

Sanskrit Text

autsukyanivṛttyartham yathā kriyāsu pravartate lokah |

puruṣasya vimokṣārthaṁ pravartate tadvad avyaktam ||

English Translation

Just as people engage in actions to relieve their desires (or curiosity), similarly the Unmanifest (Prakriti) engages in activity for the liberation of the Purusha.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
autsukyanivṛttyartham	for the purpose of relieving desire / curiosity
yathā	just as
kriyāsu	in actions
pravartate	engages
lokaḥ	the people / the world
puruṣasya	of the Purusha
vimokṣārthaṁ	for the purpose of liberation
pravartate	engages / functions
tadvad	similarly / like that
avyaktam	the unmanifest (Prakriti)

Verse 59: The Analogy of the Dancer

Sanskrit Text

raṅgasya darśayitvā nivartate nartakī yathā nr̥tyāt |
puruṣasyātmānaṁ prakāśya tathā nivartate prakṛtiḥ ||

English Translation

Just as a dancer ceases from the dance after having exhibited herself to the audience, so does Prakriti cease (from her evolutionary activity) after having manifested herself to the Purusha.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
raṅgasya	to the audience / stage
darśayitvā	having shown / exhibited
nivartate	ceases / withdraws
nartakī	the dancer
yathā	just as
nr̥tyāt	from the dance
puruṣasya	to the Purusha

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
ātmānaṁ	herself
prakāśya	having manifested / illuminated
tathā	similarly
nivartate	ceases / withdraws
prakṛtiḥ	Prakriti

Verse 60: Prakriti's Unselfish Service

Sanskrit Text

nānāvidhair upāyair upakāriṇy anupakāriṇaḥ puṁsaḥ |
guṇavatya aguṇasya satas tasyārtham apārthakaṁ carati ||

English Translation

Through various means, Prakriti, who is helpful and endowed with gunas, accomplishes the purpose of the Purusha, who brings no return and is devoid of gunas, acting without any benefit to herself.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
nānāvidhair	by manifold / various

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
upāyair	means
upakāriṇy	helpful / benevolent
anupakāriṇaḥ	of the non-helpful / bringing no return
puṁsaḥ	of the Purusha
guṇavaty	endowed with gunas
aguṇasya	of the one without gunas
satas	being (thus)
tasya	his
artham	purpose
apārthakaṁ	without purpose (for herself) / uselessly
carati	acts / goes about

Samkhya Karika Study Guide: Volume 7

(Verses 61-72)

This seventh and final volume concludes our deep dive into Ishvarakrishna's Samkhya Karika, covering verses 61 through 72. These concluding verses eloquently describe the delicate nature of Prakriti, the ultimate truth that Purusha is never bound, the dawn of pure knowledge ("I am not, naught is mine"), the state of the liberated sage while living (Jivanmukti), final liberation (Videhamukti), and the lineage of this profound philosophical system.

Verse 61: The Delicacy of Prakriti

Sanskrit Text

prakṛteḥ sukumārataram na kiñcid astīti me matir bhavati |
yā dr̥ṣṭāsmi iti punar na darśanam upaiti puruṣasya ||

English Translation

Nothing is more modest and delicate than Prakriti; such is my conviction. Thinking, "I have been seen," she never again comes into the sight of the Purusha.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
prakṛteḥ	than Prakriti
sukumārataram	more delicate / more modest

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
na kiñcid	nothing
astīti	is (thus)
me	my
matir bhavati	belief/mind is
yā	who
dr̥ṣṭāsmi	"I have been seen"
iti	thus
punar na	never again
darśanam upaiti	comes into sight
puruṣasya	of Purusha

Verse 62: The Truth of Bondage and Liberation

Sanskrit Text

tasman na badhyate'ddhā na mucyate nāpi saṁsarati kaścit |
saṁsarati badhyate mucyate ca nānāśrayā prakṛtiḥ ||

English Translation

Therefore, in reality, no Purusha is bound, nor liberated, nor transmigrates. It is Prakriti, abiding in various forms, that transmigrates, is bound, and is liberated.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tasmān	therefore
na badhyate	is not bound
addhā	in reality / truly
na mucyate	is not liberated
nāpi saṁsarati	nor transmigrates
kaścit	anyone / any Purusha
saṁsarati	transmigrates
badhyate	is bound
mucyate ca	and is liberated
nānāśrayā	abiding in various forms / supporting many
prakṛtiḥ	Prakriti

Verse 63: Prakriti's Binding and Releasing

Sanskrit Text

rūpaiḥ saptabhir eva tu badhnāty ātmānam ātmanā prakṛtiḥ |
saiva ca puruṣārthaṁ prati vimocayaty ekarūpeṇa ||

English Translation

Prakriti binds herself by herself through seven forms (virtue, vice, ignorance, power, weakness, passion, dispassion). And she herself liberates herself for the sake of the Purusha by one form (pure knowledge).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
rūpaiḥ	by forms / dispositions
saptabhir	by seven
eva tu	indeed / but
badhnāty	binds
ātmānam	herself
ātmanā	by herself
prakṛtiḥ	Prakriti

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
saiva ca	and she herself
puruṣārthaṁ prati	for the purpose of Purusha
vimocayaty	liberates
ekarūpeṇa	by one form (knowledge)

Verse 64: The Dawn of Pure Knowledge

Sanskrit Text

evaṁ tattvābhyāsān nāsmi na me nāham ity aparīśeṣam |
 aviparyayād viśuddhaṁ kevalam utpadyate jñānam ||

English Translation

Thus, from the practice of truth (the Tattvas), there arises the absolute, pure, and errorless knowledge: "I am not, naught is mine, there is no Ego," leaving no residue.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
evaṁ	thus
tattvābhyāsān	from the practice of the truth / principles

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
nāsmi	I am not (no agency)
na me	not mine (no attachment)
nāham	not "I" (no ego)
ity	thus
apariśeṣam	completely / without residue
aviparyayād	free from error / non-inverted
viśuddham	pure
kevalam	absolute / isolated
utpadyate	arises
jñānam	knowledge

Verse 65: Purusha as the Spectator

Sanskrit Text

tena nivṛttaprasavām arthavaśāt saptarūpavinivṛttām |
 prakṛtiṃ paśyati puruṣaḥ prekṣakavad avasthitaḥ svasthaḥ ||

English Translation

By this knowledge, Purusha, abiding in his own true nature and situated like a spectator, merely looks upon Prakriti, whose productiveness has ceased and who has withdrawn from her seven forms due to the fulfillment of her purpose.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
tena	by that (knowledge)
nivṛttaprasavām	whose productiveness has ceased
arthavaśāt	due to fulfillment of purpose
saptarūpavinivṛttām	withdrawn from the seven forms
prakṛtiṃ	Prakriti
paśyati	sees / looks upon
puruṣaḥ	Purusha
prekṣakavad	like a spectator
avasthitaḥ	situated / remaining
svasthaḥ	abiding in his own nature

Verse 66: The End of Evolutionary Motive

Sanskrit Text

dr̥ṣṭā mayety upekṣaka eko dr̥ṣṭāham ity uparamaty anyā |
sati saṁyoge'pi tayoh prayojanaṁ nāsti sargasya ||

English Translation

"She has been seen by me," says the one (Purusha), and becomes indifferent. "I have been seen," says the other (Prakriti), and ceases acting. Even though the conjunction between them remains, there is no longer any motive for creation.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
dr̥ṣṭā mayā	"she has been seen by me"
ity	thus
upekṣaka	indifferent / unconcerned
eko	the one (Purusha)
dr̥ṣṭāham	"I have been seen"
ity	thus
uparamaty	ceases / stops

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
anyā	the other (Prakriti)
sati saṁyoge'pi	even though conjunction remains
tayoh	of the two
prayojanaṁ	motive / purpose
nāsti	is not
sargasya	for creation

Verse 67: Liberation While Living (Jivanmukti)

Sanskrit Text

samyagjñānādhigamād dharmādīnām akāraṇaprāptau |
tiṣṭhati saṁskāraśāc cakrabhramavad dhṛtaśarīraḥ ||

English Translation

Upon the attainment of perfect knowledge, virtue and the other dispositions lose their causal power to generate further bodies. However, the sage remains invested with the current body due to the momentum of past impressions (Samskaras), just as a potter's wheel continues to whirl (after the action of the potter has stopped).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
samyagjñānādhigamād	upon attainment of perfect knowledge
dharmādīnām	of virtue and the rest
akāraṇaprāptau	having lost causal power
tiṣṭhati	remains
saṁskāraśāc	due to the force of past impressions / momentum
cakrabhramavad	like the whirling of a wheel
dhṛtaśarīraḥ	retaining the body

Verse 68: Final Liberation (Videhamukti)

Sanskrit Text

prāpte śarīrabhede caritārthatvāt pradhānavinivṛttau |
aikāntikam ātyantikam ubhayaṁ kaivalyam āpnoti ||

English Translation

When the separation from the body is attained (at death), and Pradhana (Prakriti) completely ceases its activity because her purpose has been fulfilled, Purusha attains absolute and permanent liberation (Kaivalya).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
prāpte	when attained
śarīrabhede	separation from the body (death)
caritārthatvāt	because the purpose is fulfilled
pradhānavinivṛttau	when Pradhana ceases activity
aikāntikam	absolute (freedom from pain)
ātyantikam	permanent (non-return)
ubhayam	both
kaivalyam	liberation / isolation
āpnoti	attains

Verse 69: The Origin of the Doctrine

Sanskrit Text

puruṣārthajñānam idaṁ guhyam paramarṣiṇā samākhyātam |
sthityutpattipralayāś cintyante yatra bhūtānām ||

English Translation

This profound and secret knowledge, intended for the purpose of the Purusha—in which the origin, duration, and dissolution of all beings are investigated—was declared by the great sage (Kapila).

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
puruṣārthajñānam	knowledge for the purpose of Purusha
idaṁ	this
guhyam	secret / profound
paramarṣiṇā	by the great sage (Kapila)
samākhyātam	was declared / expounded
sthyitpattipralayāś	duration, origin, and dissolution
cintyante	are considered / investigated
yatra	where / in which
bhūtānām	of beings / elements

Verse 70: The Lineage of Transmission

Sanskrit Text

etat pavitram agryam munir āsuraye'nukampayā pradadau |
āsurir api pañcaśikhāya tena ca bahudhā kṛtam tantram ||

English Translation

This supreme and purifying knowledge the Sage (Kapila) imparted out of compassion to Asuri. Asuri, in turn, imparted it to Panchashikha, by whom this system was widely expanded.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
etat	this
pavitram	purifying
agryam	supreme / foremost
munir	the sage (Kapila)
āsuraye	to Asuri
anukampayā	out of compassion
pradadau	gave / imparted
āsurir api	Asuri also

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
pañcaśikhāya	to Panchashikha
tena ca	and by him
bahudhā kṛtaṁ	was made manifold / widely expanded
tantram	the system / doctrine

Verse 71: The Author of the Karika

Sanskrit Text

śiṣyaparamparayāgatam īśvarakṛṣṇena caitad āryābhiḥ |
saṁkṣiptam āryamatina samyag vijñāya siddhāntam ||

English Translation

Handed down through a continuous succession of disciples, this doctrine has been summarized in the Arya meter by the noble-minded Ishvarakrishna, who has thoroughly understood the established principles.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
śiṣyaparamparayā	by the succession of disciples
āgatam	handed down / come

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
Íśvarakṛṣṇena	by Ishvarakrishna
caitad	and this
āryābhiḥ	in the Arya meter
saṁkṣiptam	summarized
āryamatina	by the noble-minded
samyag	thoroughly / rightly
vijñāya	having understood
siddhāntam	the established doctrine / principles

Verse 72: The Completeness of the Text

Sanskrit Text

saptatyāṁ kila ye'rthās te'rthāḥ kṛtsnasya ṣaṣṭītantrasya |
ākhyāyikāvirahitāḥ paravādavivarjitāś cāpi ||

English Translation

The subjects treated in these seventy verses are indeed those of the entire Shashtitantra (the science of sixty topics), minus the illustrative tales and the refutation of other philosophical

doctrines.

Word-by-Word Breakdown

Sanskrit Word	English Meaning
saptatyāṁ	in the seventy (verses)
kila	indeed
ye'rthās	which subjects / topics
te'rthāḥ	those subjects
kṛtsnasya	of the entire
ṣaṣṭitantrasya	of the Shashtitantra
ākhyāyikāvirahitāḥ	devoid of illustrative stories
paravādavivarjitāś	devoid of refutations of others' theories
cāpi	and also